that had been left in shambles by its boy king and the challenger for the imperial throne. By 1278, he had managed to do all three. Ottocar had finally been killed, fighting his lord on the banks of the Danube. Rudolf had destroyed sixty castles occupied by bandits and private warlords; he had whipped the troublesome kingdom of Moravia into line; he had made a marriage alliance between Ottocar's son Wenceslaus and his own daughter, and made another treaty with the king of Hungary. He had restored Frederick's laws, and spent countless months traveling through Germany, visiting each local court. He took as his motto the Latin *Melius bene imperare, quam imperium ampliare:* Better to govern the empire well than to enlarge it.[2]

Meanwhile, Charles of Anjou was ruling his double kingdom of southern Italy and Sicily ("The Kingdom of the Two Sicilies") with equally close attention to detail. In Charles's case, though, the attention was paid to his own power.

In 1280, after the sudden death of the current pope (Nicholas III, who had lasted all of three years as pontiff), Charles meddled directly in the papal elections. He favored the election of the Franciscan Simon de Brion, a native of Tours. When the Italian cardinals objected to the election of another Frenchman, Charles imprisoned two of them. The rest, properly intimidated, elevated Brion to the papal seat. The new French pope, who took the name Martin IV, was so unpopular in Italy that he did not dare enter Rome; he had to be consecrated at Orvieto, north of Saint Peter's city.

As supreme head of Christ's church, Martin IV was ruled by two overwhelming considerations: how to find his next gourmet meal, and how to please Charles of Anjou. His greed was relatively harmless (although in the *Divine Comedy*, Dante's narrator encounters Martin IV, in purgatory, still doing penance for his overindulgence in eels and rich Muscadel wine). His willingness to further Charles's ambitions was less benign. He gave Charles the position of Senator of Rome, promoted pro-Anjou French priests into positions of power, and threw his complete agreement behind Charles's newest scheme: to conquer Constantinople for himself.[3]

For this scheme, Charles had recruited two allies. The Doge of Venice, still smarting over the Genoese monopoly in Constantinople, agreed to send ships; the defeated Latin emperor Baldwin, who had taken refuge in Italy after fleeing from Michael VIII's troops, hoped to regain his throne under Charles's protection. In 1282, Charles was given the perfect opportunity to launch his war against Byzantium. Michael VIII, still attempting to whip his anti-union protesters into line, died; and his son Andronicus II, a staunch Orthodox believer, took the throne as second emperor of the restoration. He refused to